



وَصَلَّى اللّٰهُ عَلَيْنَا يَا وَلِيَّ الْعَصْرِ اذْكُنَا

Ameerul Momineen Ali Ibn Abi Taalib (a. s.) said

الْعِلْمُ مُصْبَاحُ الْعَقْلِ

Knowledge is the lamp of wisdom*

HISTORY - 2

* Ghurar al-Hikam, Vol. 1, P. 43

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Preface

This syllabus on Islamic History has been developed by the Association of Imam Mahdi (a.s.) for its religious classes. We have taken great pains to ensure that the syllabus conforms to the Holy Quran, traditions of the Ahle Bait (a.s.) and the books of respected Shiite scholars.

Though we have tried our best to make the syllabus as accurate as possible, infallibility is only for the infallible Ahle Bait (a.s.). We will therefore appreciate if our readers come forth with valuable suggestions for improvement and point us our shortcomings.

At the end, we beseech Allah, the Almighty, to hasten the reappearance of our beloved master, Imam Mahdi (a.t.f.s.). May He include us amongst Imam's (a.t.f.s.) most sincere companions! May He grant us success in preparing the ground for Imam's (a.t.f.s.) earliest reappearance!

Aameen!

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بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

وَصَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْكَ يَا وَلِيَّ الْعَصْرِ (عج) أَذْرِكُنَا

History - II

Lesson No. 11

Imam Zainul Aabedeen (a.s.)

أَوَّلُهُمْ عَلَى سَيِّدِ الْعَابِدِينَ وَزَيْنُ أَوْلِيَاءِ الْمَاضِينَ

“The first of them (after Imam Husain (a.s.)) is Ali, the Master of worshippers and the ornament of My previous slaves.”¹

Name	: Hazrat Ali Ibn al-Husain (a.s.)
Father's name	: Hazrat Husain Ibn Ali (a.s.)
Mother's name	: The daughter of Persian Emperor Yazdjeer, Janabe Shahrbano (s.a.)
Date of Birth	: 15th Jamadi-ul-Awwal, 38 A. H.
Place of Birth	: Madinah Munawwarah
Kuniyyat	: Abu Mohammad, Abul Hasan, Abu Abdillah
Titles	: Sajjad, Zainul Aabedeen
Age	: 57 years
Martyrdom	: 25th Moharram, 95 A.H
Buried	: Jannatul Baqi, Madinah Munawwarah

Birth

Imam Zainul Aabedeen (a.s.) was born on 15th Jamadiul-Awwal,

38 A.H. His (a.s.) mother was a Persian princess Janabe Shahrbano who is also referred to as Shahe' Zanaan (leader of women). Imam Husain (a.s.) named him “Ali” after his respected father. At the tender age of two he was deprived of the loving care of his grandfather Imam Ali (a.s.). At the age of 23, he (a.s.) faced the greatest tragedy of his life i.e. the event of Karbala. Since he was his father's successor and the divine leader entrusted with the continuation of the mission of the Holy Prophet (s.a.w.a.), by the will of Allah, Imam Sajjad (a.s.) was seriously ill on the day of Aashooraa. We are aware that helping the Imam of the time is such an obligatory action that which even ordinary believers are not permitted to forsake – especially if the person is from the family of the Holy Prophet (s.a.w.a.). Thus, divine will decreed sickness for Imam Sajjad (a.s.) so that divine progeny of Imams (a.s.) may be protected. It is a wrong notion that Imam (a.s.) was always sick.

The Land of Karbala

Preserving the message of martyrdom was of utmost importance after the sacrifice of Imam Husain (a.s.). Allah decreed this responsibility be carried out by Imam Sajjad (a.s.). Imam's (a.s.) effectiveness in carrying out this task is witnessed by the popularity of this message even today. Apart from this, after Imam Husain (a.s.), since he was the only surviving male member, he (a.s.) was also entrusted with the leadership of his caravan.

The imamate of Imam Sajjad (a.s.) commenced from the noon of Aashooraa, 61 A.H. in the most difficult of situations At that time he (a.s.) was suffering from high fever and had witnessed the tragic events that occurred from morning to evening of 10th Moharram. His heart was burning on seeing the merciless killings of his family

¹ Hadees-e-Lauh, al-Kaafi, vol. 1, p. 527

members and friends one after another. At that time, the army of Yazid set to fire the tents of Imam Husain's (a.s.) camp. Being taken as prisoners, on the 11th Moharram, 61 A.H. the caravan of Imam (a.s.) started its journey. Along with the women and children, he began this journey so that he could expose the tyrannical government of Yazid. This was the most important task of Imam (a.s.) which he continued during the remaining 34 years of his Imamate. He (a.s.) kept alive and fresh, the memories of the brave martyrs of Karbala. Had it not been for this effort of Imam (a.s.), the vile government of Bani Umayyah which ruled for about 70 years after the incident of Karbala would have, through its propaganda machinery and transmission, suppressed and wiped out this event from history.

In the Court of Syria

With his extraordinary efforts, Imam (a.s.) gave everlasting life to this event. Imam's (a.s.) speech in the court of Yazid in Syria manifested his exalted character and spiritual superiority. Despite the fact that he had to bear mental and physical tortures and hardships, his orations shook the very foundations of the government of Yazid. In a place like Syria (where Imam Husain (a.s.) was considered a renegade and out of the boundaries of Islam (God forbid!) due to the poisonous propaganda of Moaviyah and Yazid) such a transformation and revolution occurred that Yazid was left with no alternative but to blame the tragic event of Karbala upon the shoulders of Ibn Ziyad, his governor in Kufa.

Yazid disgraced

In the court of Yazid, before Imam Sajjad (a.s.) ascended the pulpit, Yazid ordered one of his orators to curse Imam Ali (a.s.) and Imam Husain (a.s.) and degrade their personalities. At that time Imam Sajjad (a.s.) sought permission from Yazid to address the gathering. Yazid opposed this move, but his companions insisted that Imam (a.s.) should be allowed to speak to the gathering. Therefore, despite the protests of Yazid, he had to relent on the demands of his companions and allowed Imam (a.s.) to ascend the pulpit. When Imam (a.s.) started his speech, Yazid said to his cronies, "He has gone to the pulpit, now the only thing which will happen is defamation and disgrace for the progeny of Abu Sufyan."

The Speech of Imam (a.s.)

Imam (a.s.) in his comprehensive speech praised Allah and introduced his holy family. He introduced the personalities of the Holy Prophet (s.a.w.a.), Imam Ali (a.s.) and Imam Husain (a.s.) and the valuable services rendered by them in the way of Islam in a very eloquent manner. His speech had a great effect on the polluted minds of the Syrians. The myths regarding the government of Bani Umayyah were shattered and the true persona of Imam (a.s.) was evident for all. The speech created such an atmosphere that it provoked the people against Yazid. To defuse the tension, Yazid ordered a Muezzin to call out the Azan to silence Imam (a.s.). However, Imam (a.s.) after each and every sentence of Azan gave such a remarkable commentary, which resulted in increased disgrace for Yazid. In short, it was after this event that Yazid was forced to hide his face. As indicated earlier Yazid resorted to

compromise and peace and ordered a mourning ceremony for Imam Husain (a.s.). After a few days he gave the order for Imam (a.s.) and all the prisoners to return to Madinah.¹

Return to Madinah

At the time of entering Madinah, Imam (a.s.) addressed the people who had come forward to receive the caravan with heart rendering sentences and reminded them of the oppression inflicted by the Bani Umayyah on his family. Here Imam (a.s.) did not complain at all about those sufferings but instead he praised and thanked Allah and said:

أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ إِنَّ اللَّهَ تَعَالَى وَلَهُ الْحَدُّ ابْتَلَانَا بِصَائِبٍ وَثُبَّةٍ فِي
الْإِسْلَامِ عَظِيمَةٍ قَتَلَ أَبُو عَبْدِ اللَّهِ الْحُسَيْنُ وَعِثْرَتُهُ...

“O People! Surely Almighty Allah for whom belongs praise engaged us in a difficulty which is very great in Islam. Imam Husain (a.s.) and his family were martyred....”²

Here in this statement he pointed out the martyrdom of Imam Husain (a.s.) as a great calamity for Islam and he ended with the following sentence:

فَعِنْدَ اللَّهِ نَحْتَسِبُ مُصَابِنَا وَمَا بَدَعَ بِنَا فَإِنَّهُ عَزِيزٌ ذُو انْتِقَامٍ.

“Then with Allah is our great reward of our calamities and He is the best of those who take revenge”

On one side he practically demonstrated his patience and steadfastness and on the other he reminded about the omnipotence of Allah, who would take revenge.

Imam (a.s.) during 34 years of Imamate passed through the reigns of five caliphs of Bani Umayyah. They were Yazid Ibn Moaviah, Moaviah Ibn Yazid, Marwan Ibn Hakam, Abdul Malik Ibn Marwan and Walid Ibn Abdul Malik. All of them tried their best to harm Imam (a.s.) except Moaviah Ibn Yazid. (As soon as he received the caliphate, he declared the Bani Umayyah as the unlawful usurpers of the Islamic caliphate and considering himself as the wrongful caliph, resigned from the post).

Training the People

After the incident of Karbala, Imam (a.s.) adopted two important and fundamental methods to discharge his duties of leadership (Imamate). The first method was that he focused his attention on the individual and collective training of the people. His eloquent expressions in this regard were presented in the form of supplications. (An exquisite collection of these supplications is present today in the form of Sahifah-e-Sajjadiyah.) He (a.s.) also undertook the training of his slaves. For this purpose, at the start of every year, the representatives of Imam (a.s.) used to purchase a group of slaves. These slaves would remain under the training of Imam (a.s.) for one year and thereafter would be freed to return to their homeland. In this fashion, the principles of Shiite Islam were propagated.

¹ Al-Imam Ali Ibn Husain (a.s.), Ali Mohammad Dokhayyal, pp. 39-41

² Ibid, p. 42; Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 45, p. 147 narrating from Lohooof of Sayed Ibn Taawoos (r.a.)

The Treatise of Rights

Another important work of Imam (a.s.) which is present even today is the treatise famous as ‘Resaalatul Huquq’.¹ It is a collection of individual and social rights of the Muslims. In the discussion of rights, this book is one of the earliest Islamic references. Even the fifteen whispered prayers (Munajaat-e-Khamsa Ashar) are among the other invocations and prayers which have reached us from him (a.s.).

The second method adopted by Imam (a.s.) was to protect the memory of the revolution of Karbala. As has been pointed earlier, Bani Umayyah tried their best to wash their hands off the blemish and disgrace of the event of Karbala. For this purpose, their speakers started work on the above matter right from the days of the superficial repentance of Yazid. In such a situation it was solely upon Imam (a.s.) that he protects the memory of this great and precious event. That is why we see that during his lifetime, whenever during the year there was a gathering for mourning or when he used to witness the slaughtering of a sheep in any street, he used to cry copiously. The people used to be attentive towards him to listen to his narration and in that emotionally charged atmosphere, he would remind them of the role of the Bani Umayyah in the incident of Karbala and also narrate the virtues of the Household of the Holy Prophet (s.a.w.a.).

Among the characteristics of Imam Sajjad (a.s.), which are reported from his son Imam Mohammad Baqir (a.s.) is that he would cover his face and go out in the city of Madinah to meet the

needs of the poor and the needy himself. Whenever he met a needy person on the way who would express his need to him, he (a.s.) would welcome him with these words:

مَرْحَبًا بِمَنْ يَحْمِلُ زَادِي إِلَى الْآخِرَةِ

“Welcome, O, the one who carries my provisions towards the hereafter.”¹

His Morals and Worship

In the worship of Allah, he (a.s.) was so attentive that he was given the title of ‘Sajjad’ (one who prostrates a lot) and ‘Zainul Aabedeem’ (the adornment of Worshipers). In terms of dealing with the people, it is famous that he had an extraordinary tolerant and forgiving attitude. Whenever he heard somebody speak ill of him, he would not get angry, but would say,

إِنْ كَانَ مَا قُلْتَهُ فِي حَقِّنَا حَقًّا فَاللَّهُ تَعَالَى يَغْفِرْ لِي وَإِنْ كَانَ مَا قُلْتَهُ فِي حَقِّنَا بَاطِلًا فَاللَّهُ تَعَالَى يَغْفِرْ لَكَ.

“If whatever you said about me is true, may Allah forgive me and if whatever you said about me is false, then, may Allah forgive you.”

It was due to these characteristics and personality of Imam (a.s.) that when the soldiers of Bani Umayyah attacked Madinah and committed various heinous crimes, they did not have courage to

¹ Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 46, p. 98, Ch. 5, H. 86 narrating from Kashf al-Ghummah of Irbili (r.a.)

¹ This has been translated into Urdu as well as English.

trouble Imam (a.s.). On the contrary they declared his holy house as a safe haven. All who took shelter in his house were thus spared. This attack of the army of Yazid is famous as ‘Hurrah’ in the history. This was another disgrace upon Bani Umayyah.

The Greatness of Imam (a.s.)

The popularity and esteem enjoyed by the Imam (a.s.) amongst the people can be gauged from an incident during the Hajj. Hisham Ibn Abdul Malik – the Umayyad King – wanted to kiss the Hajarul Aswad (black stone) but was not successful due to the large crowd. At the same time the people were moving aside in order to give way to Imam Sajjad (a.s.) who was moving freely towards Hajarul Aswad and calmly kissed it. At that time, someone asked Hisham: “Who is this person?” Though he had recognized Imam (a.s.) he feigned ignorance about the man, he pretended and said he did not know him. At that moment, Farazdaq, a renowned poet, recited a wonderful and lengthy couplet in praise of Imam (a.s.).

Martyrdom

The love and popularity of the Imam (a.s.) amongst the people was unbearable for the Umayyad rulers and became the cause of Imam (a.s.) being poisoned on the order of Walid Ibn Abdul Malik. He (a.s.) was buried in the graveyard of Baqi next to the grave of Imam Hasan (a.s.).

Sahifah-e-Sajjadiyah

It is very essential to note at the end of this lesson that the valuable sayings of Imam (a.s.) on various topics in Sahifah-e-Sajjadiyah should be carefully paid attention to by us. Firstly, all the

supplications in this collection commence with the blessings on the Holy Prophet (s.a.w.a.) and his progeny. This opens the doors of divine mercy for the acceptance of the supplications. Imam (a.s.) in the form of supplications has discussed various topics which include, remembering the martyrs who were enjoining goodness and forbidding evil, guarding of Islam, protecting the frontiers of Islam, supporting the truth and crushing the falsehood, helping those who have no support in the society, peace and security in the society, etc. These are springs of guidance for us. The intelligent should therefore seek guidance from it. They contain an elaborate and necessary blueprint for the principles of this life. These supplications conceal among them a comprehensive collection of Islamic teachings. Along with seeking forgiveness for sins, these supplications are the best source for purifying the self and Islamic training. A translation of these supplications is available both in Urdu and English.

Lesson No. 12

Imam Muhammad Baqir (a.s.)

شِبْهُ جَدِّهِ الْحُجُودِ مُحَمَّدٍ الْبَاقِرِ لِعَلِيٍّ وَالْبَعْدُ لِحَكْمَتِي.

“(Imam Baqir) who is like his beloved grandfather (Holy Prophet) (s.a.w.a.), the splitter of My knowledge and the mine of My wisdom.”¹

Name	: Hazrat Muhammad Ibn Ali (a.s.)
Father's name	: Imam Sajjad (a.s.)
Mother's name	: Fatimah binte Imam Hasan (a.s.) (agnomen was Ummo Abdillah)
Date of Birth	: 1 st Rajab, 57 A. H.
Place of Birth	: Madinah Munawwarah
Kuniyyat	: Abu Ja'far
Titles	: Ameen, Haadi, Saabir, Shaahid, Baqir, etc.
Age	: 57 years
Martyrdom	: 7th Zilhijja, 114 A.H
Buried	: Jannatul Baqi, Madinah Munawwarah

On Friday, the 1st of Rajab, 57 A.H., in the family of Imam Sajjad (a.s.), from his wife Ummo Abdillah (daughter of Imam Hasan Mujtaba (a.s.)) in the city of Madinah, a son was born who was

named Muhammad. This dear child who was for some time witnessed his grandfather Imam Husain (a.s.), was present in the event of Karbala, at the age of about 4 years and in his childhood witnessed the heart rending event. Together, with the other children he was dragged from one place to another as captive in the hands of Yazeed's agents, with the caravan, moving from Kufa to Syria. He lived for 34 years during the Imamate of his father, Imam Sajjad (a.s.) and after his demise, attained Imamate in the year 95 A.H. He was in charge of Shia leadership for 19 years.

Years before his birth, when the Holy Prophet (s.a.w.a.) was talking to his famous companion, Jabir Ibn Abdullah Ansari about his successors, told him that the fifth of them bears my name and is from the lineage of Husain. You, O Jabir, will also meet him. So, convey my salaam to him. Divine Destiny extended the age of Jabir and at long last the foretelling of the God's Prophet (s.a.w.a.) turned to reality and he conveyed the message to Imam Baqir (a.s.). 'Baqir' literally means 'splitter' and various sciences appeared in the time of this Imam which will be enumerated later in the chapter. Hence the title was given to the Imam.

This is was same title bestowed upon him by the Prophet (s.a.w.a.) long before his birth and while explaining the word to Jabir, he said:

يَقْرَأُ عِلْمَ النَّبِيِّينَ بَقْرًا.

“He will split up the knowledge of Prophets extensively.”¹

During his Imamate which was the time of the downfall of the

¹ Hadees-e-Lauh, Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 36, p. 196, Ch. 40, narrating from al-Kaafi, vol. 1, p. 528

¹ Al-Manaaqib of Shahre Aashob, vol. 2, p. 285

government of Bani Umayyah – Walid Ibn Abdul Malik, Sulaiman Ibn Abdul Malik, Umar Ibn Abdul Aziz, Yazid Ibn Abdul Malik and Hisham Ibn Abdul Malik ruled over the Muslim Empire. Since many movements arose in varied parts of the Islamic society against these oppressive rulers of Bani Umayyah, the government was gradually drawn towards its downfall. As a result, most of the ruling power was utilized in silencing revolts and to a large extent, the government was unable to harass Imam (a.s.). The event of Karbala and the sensitive role played by Imam Sajjad (a.s.) in preserving its memory played an effective part in the above mentioned revolts. During the 19 years of his Imamate, Imam Baqir (a.s.) took advantage of the disturbed condition of governance in establishing the cultural foundation of the Shia school of thought, inspite of the pressures of the previous rulers who had tried hard to wipe the traditions of the Holy Prophet (s.a.w.a.) and Imams (a.s.) from public memory.

The Dissemination of Knowledge

These times became the perfect opportunity for compilation and giving shape to the foundation and principles of religion. Therefore, this was a period where comprehensive facts of the divine religion were being explained by Imam (a.s.), after a long era of intellectual and mental suffocation, created by the Umayyid and their harsh attitude towards preventing the truthful teachings of Islam.

Thus, a number of students from all over the Islamic world gathered around the Imam (a.s.) in Madinah and derived benefit from his wisdom and knowledge. Jabir Ibn Yazid Ju'fi says: I have heard more than 70000 traditions from the Imam that none except

him has narrated. Muhammad Ibn Muslim, a distinguished companion of Imam (a.s.) also says: Whatever problems that had arisen, I sought the opinion of Imam about them so much so that I heard over 30000 traditions from him. This resulted in the establishment of a great centre of learning in Madinah.

The present Umayyad caliphs, not unlike their predecessors, tried to create hindrances, even to the extent of ordering their governors in Madinah to send the Imam (a.s.) to Damascus under custody so that his activities would get curtailed.

Status of Imam (a.s.)

Once when Abdul Malik Ibn Marwan had given such an order, the governor of Madinah, while refusing to act upon it, advised the caliph.

On pondering over some of the phrases of this letter, we view the comprehensive personality of Imam Baqir (a.s.) as described by an agent of the shameful Umayyad government (whose enmity with the Prophet's household (a.s.) is evident). He writes in the letter:

إِنَّ الرَّجُلَ الَّذِي أَرَدْتَهُ لَيْسَ الْيَوْمَ عَلَى وَجْهِ الْأَرْضِ أَعَفَّ مِنْهُ
وَلَا أَزْهَدَ وَلَا أَوْرَعَ مِنْهُ وَإِنَّهُ مِنْ أَعْلَمِ النَّاسِ وَأَرْقَى النَّاسِ وَأَشَدِّ
النَّاسِ اجْتِهَادًا وَعِبَادَةً وَكَرْهَتْ لِأَمِيرِ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ التَّعَرُّضَ لَهُ
فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يُغَيِّرُ مَا بِقَوْمٍ حَتَّى يُغَيِّرُوا مَا بِأَنْفُسِهِمْ.

Surely (as to) the person you have asked for, there is none on the face of this earth today as forgiving, ascetic and

pious as him. He is the most learned, most wise and the most devoted of people in the matter of worship and striving. I think it improper on the part of the Caliph to commit aggression against him. (Thereafter he quotes a verse of the noble Qur'an) Allah does not change the condition of a nation till they change it for themselves (pointing to the fact that if you do wrong to the Imam, you will meet an evil end).¹

We see that the illuminated personality of the Imam extracted such a testimony from his enemy.

An Advice

In his personal life, he was sanctified with special virtues. As far as possible, he worked personally to fulfill his own needs. Once at an advanced age, he was seen toiling in the field. A person addressed him: why are you working so hard for this material world, putting in such effort? If you happen to meet death in this state, what will you do? Imam (a.s.), in a fluent and eloquent rebuttal, denounced the ways and means of the people who pretend to be pious (through deviated beliefs) and ignorant advisors, said:

لَوْ جَاءَنِي وَاللَّهِ الْمَوْتُ وَأَنَا فِي هَذِهِ الْحَالِ لَجَأْتَنِي وَأَنَا فِي طَاعَةٍ مِنْ
طَاعَاتِ اللَّهِ أَكْفُ بِهَا نَفْسِي عَنْكَ وَعَنِ النَّاسِ وَإِنِّي كُنْتُ أَخَافُ
الْمَوْتَ لَوْ جَاءَنِي وَأَنَا عَلَى مَعْصِيَةٍ مِنْ مَعَاصِي اللَّهِ.

¹ Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 46, p. 329, Ch. 8, H. 12 narrating from al-Kharaaej wa al-Jaraaeh of Qutbuddin al-Raawandi (a.r.)

By Allah, if death does come upon me in this state, while (I am glad) I am obeying one of the orders of Allah; I render myself independent of you and others (like you). I fear death only at the time when I am disobeying Allah.¹

This manner and behavior of the Imam is a lesson for us that endeavor in worldly affairs is reckoned by him as worship and obedience to Allah. Surely, this attention towards the world has an aim and is not out of love for the world. On the contrary, it is a means for the provisions of the next world and should be considered in conjunction with the affairs of the hereafter which is a must for every realistic Muslim.

In order to refrain from the impression that by mentioning Imam's plan for the spread of fundamental Islamic sciences, we have kept the Imam separate from social affairs and to reveal the versatile personality of Imam, we reproduce two historical incidents at this juncture.

The Syrian Court

On one occasion when Hisham Ibn Abdul Malik had ordered the Imam to be forcibly bought to Damascus, Imam (a.s.) entered his palace in the Islamic manner (not in official court etiquette) and after offering salaam to the audience he took a seat in a corner. This obviously irked Hisham who was accustomed to a different mode of address by his sycophants. He tried to humiliate Imam (a.s.) branding his family as factors of discord and disunity, calling them false leaders. The sycophants too, despite the Imam's stand, offered false respect to Hisham in the same un-Islamic custom. At

¹ Alaamul Waraa, p. 263, Fusulul Muhimma, p. 196

this juncture, Imam (a.s.) objected and in the grand court of Hisham, spoke so categorically defending the dignity of the Holy household of the Prophet (s.a.w.a.), that everyone in the hall was stunned. At the end of his speech, he recited a Qur'anic verse 'وَالْعَاقِبَةُ لِلتَّقِيْنَ' and sarcastically reminded him that ultimate success and victory for the pious ones. Upon this, Hisham ordered the imprisonment of Imam (a.s.).

In the prison, the other inmates gathered around him devoutly. When Hisham realized that he, by his own hands, had created another center of revolution, had no other choice but to release Imam (a.s.) and send him back to Madinah honourably.¹

Therefore, whenever the occasion permitted, and when they saw that the Islamic basics were in danger and when un-Islamic elements like the Umayyad caliph intended to degrade the great personalities, the Imams (a.s.) spoke out courageously and fearlessly.

Admonishment to the Ruler

Among the contemporary caliphs of Imam (a.s.), Umar Ibn Abdul Aziz was comparatively soft in his behavior towards him. He amicably maintained the sanctity of Imam (a.s.). One day he asked Imam (a.s.) for advice. Imam (a.s.) in a lucid and brief statement taught him the manners of an Islamic ruler, with respect to the different classes of society in the following manner:

أَوْصِيكَ أَنْ تَتَّخِذَ صَغِيرَ الْمُسْلِمِينَ وَلَدًا وَأَوْسَطَهُمْ أَخًا وَكَبِيرَهُمْ

أَبَا فَا رَحِمَ وَلَدَكَ وَصِلْ أَخَاكَ وَبِرَّ أَبَاكَ وَإِذَا صَنَعْتَ مَعْرُوفًا فَرِّبْهُ
(أَبَى أَدِمُّهُ).

I recommend you to adopt the Muslim children as your own. Treat young Muslims like your own brothers. Consider the aged Muslims like your own father. Therefore, be grateful to your child, be bound to your brother and do good to your father. In case you begin to do a good and desirable deed, develop and continue it.¹

We see that as far as preaching is concerned, Imam (a.s.) gives a reminder of whatever is necessary even to the powerful caliph in a fearless manner.

Nonetheless, during the 19 years of Imam, he endeavored in all respects to spread the sciences of the Prophet's household (a.s.) as far as social capacity allowed and the people were in a position to bear them. At the same time, he asserted himself at times on the rulers of the dwindling Umayyad power. In this way, he would show to the people that Imams were the only solution who could show their special prowess in every field and were not unilaterally inclined.

Archery

In another of the forced journeys to Damascus which the Imam (a.s.) undertook at Hisham's connivance, he was brought to the shooting ground. Hisham, compelled the Imam (a.s.) who was aged

¹ Al-Manaaqib of Shahre Aashob, vol. 2, p. 280

¹ Al-Muhammad al-Baqir, p. 43

at the time, to shoot the target. Initially, Imam (a.s.) resisted the request. But Hisham, taking an oath obliged Imam (a.s.) to shoot. He tried to demonstrate his powers and wanted to show off in front of Imam (a.s.) to the audience that he was the bonafide claimant of rulership while Imam (a.s.) was ignorant in the ways of fighting (which is an essential quality of leadership and administration).

Unexpectedly, he saw Imam (a.s.) holding the bow and arrow and shooting 9 arrows straight at the target one after the other. Further astonishment lay in store. Imam (a.s.) shot the arrows in such a way that the first arrow hit the target and the subsequent arrows pierced straight through the tail of the earlier ones. The caliph grew upset at this demonstration of skill and asked him where he had mastered such skills in archery. The reply was: this is from our childhood in Madinah. The caliph, at this juncture, felt so ashamed that he ordered the Imam to be returned to Madinah with full respect.

Imparting Knowledge

Imam (a.s.) played a profound role in laying the foundation of classes for teaching Islam, giving shape to the school of thought and putting down in writing the basics of Islamic culture. This path and method was also adopted by his honourable son. Islamic sciences developed and spread a great deal during this period. Young students of Imam (a.s.) gained universal fame in the vast Islamic territories. Today, Shia texts are full of explanations given by Imam Baqir (a.s.). The Imam (a.s.) initiated the way for countering the misleading philosophical concepts that were adopting Islamic colour.

Martyrdom

Finally on Monday, the 7th of Zilhijja in the year 114 A.H., Imam (a.s.) was poisoned on the direction of Ibrahim Ibn Walid Ibn Abdul Malik and he departed from this world at the age of 57. He, like his father and ancestor (Imam Hasan (a.s.)) was buried in the Baqi graveyard. Even today, his grave, next to the shrine of his father, his ancestor and children in the Baqi cemetery, is the shrine for thousands of devotees of monotheism, justice and knowledge. A glance upon the history of Imam Baqir (a.s.) may be brought to conclusion with the mention of two of his invaluable sayings in the field of knowledge and justice.

Narrations

Regarding the value of knowledge, he says:

لَكُونُوا عَالِمًا أَحَبُّ إِلَى ابْلِيسَ مِنْ مَوْتِ سَبْعِينَ عَابِدًا

The death of a scholar is much dearer to the Shaitan than the dying of 70 worshippers.¹

إِنَّ أَشَدَّ النَّاسِ حَسْرَةً يَوْمَ الْقِيَامَةِ عَبْدٌ وَصَفَ عَدْلًا ثُمَّ خَالَفَهُ إِلَى غَيْرِهِ

Surely the most miserable of men on Judgement Day will be the one who commands justice but resorts to cruelty and excesses.²

¹ Ayaanush Shia, vol. 4, part II, p. 20

² Ayaanush Shia, vol. 4, part II, p. 24

Lesson No. 13

Imam Ja'far Sadiq (a.s.)

حَقِّ الْقَوْلُ مِنِّي لَأُكْرِمَنَّ مَشْوَى جَعْفَرٍ وَلَا سُرَّتَهُ فِي أَشْيَاعِهِ وَ
أَنْصَارِهِ وَأَوْلِيَّائِهِ

“It is My true saying (promise) that I will make honourable the position of Ja'far and will make him glad with regard to his followers, companions and friends.”¹

Name	: Hazrat Ja'far Ibn Muhammad (a.s.)
Father's name	: Imam Baqir (a.s.)
Mother's name	: Fatimah (Umme Farwah) (s.a.)
Date of Birth	: 17 th Rabiul Awwal, 83 A. H.
Place of Birth	: Madinah Munawwarah
Kuniyyat	: Abu Abdillah
Titles	: Sadiq, Saabir, Faazil, Taahir, etc.
Age	: 65 years
Martyrdom	: 15th Rajab, 148 A.H.
Buried	: Jannatul Baqi, Madinah Munawwarah

Birth

On Friday, the 17th of Rabiul Awwal, 83 A.H., in the house of Imam Muhammad Baqir (a.s.), from his wife Fatimah (Umme Farwah), a son was born who was named Ja'far. Much before his birth, when the Almighty Allah had informed his Prophet about his 12 successors, this child (who was later called Imam Ja'far Sadiq, known by agnomen as Abu Abdillah and who took charge of the guardianship of the society after his father) was remembered thus:

سَيَهْلِكُ الْبُرْتَابُونَ فِي جَعْفَرٍ الرَّادُّ عَلَيْهِ كَالرَّادِّ عَلَى حَقِّ الْقَوْلِ مِنِّي
لَأُكْرِمَنَّ مَشْوَى جَعْفَرٍ وَلَا سُرَّتَهُ فِي أَشْيَاعِهِ وَأَنْصَارِهِ وَأَوْلِيَّائِهِ.

Those who carry doubt about Ja'far would be destroyed. He who does not accept him, it is as if he has not accepted Me. It is My true saying (promise) that I will make honourable the position of Ja'far and will make him glad with regard to his followers, companions and friends.¹

Caliphs of his Time

Imam (a.s.) passed his childhood during the period of his father and magnanimous grandfather. With the martyrdom of Imam Baqir (a.s.) in 114 A.H., he ascended to the Imamate and divine caliphate at the age of 31 years. The period of this Imam closely resembled that of his father Baqir (a.s.) because the revolutionary activities against the Umayyid rule had intensified and the final of the

¹ Hadees-e-Lauh, Al-Kaafi, vol. 1, p. 528

¹ A part of Hadees-e-Lauh narrated from Kitabul Hujjah of Usool-e-Kafi

dynastic links was breathing its last years of rule. Imam Sadiq (a.s.) was contemporary to five Umayyid caliphs and two caliphs of Bani Abbas. They are Hisham Ibn Abdul Malik, Walid Ibn Yazid Ibn Abdul Malik, Yazid Ibn Walid Ibn Abdul Malik, Ibrahim Ibn Walid and Marwan Ibn Muhammad (these 5 were Umayyid caliphs. The last was notorious in history as Marwane Himaar. (Himaar means donkey) With his assassination, the Umayyid dynasty came to an end). Saffaah and Mansoor Dawaneqi were the other two caliphs who belonged to Bani Abbas.

Propagation of Islam

The resemblance of the periods of Imam Sadiq (a.s.) and Imam Baqir (a.s.) was the reason for Imam Sadiq (a.s.) in adopting and continuing the precedent set by his father in the spread of Islamic teachings and culture. According to most historians, this progressed to an extent where 4000 pupils participated in his classes in Madinah for learning diversified sciences.¹

Students of Imam (a.s.)

Among his students were world famous personalities like Zurarah, Muhammad Ibn Muslim, Hisham Ibn Hakam, Abaan Ibn Taghlib and Jabir Ibn Hayyaan. Even some of the top Sunni leaders were among those had gained knowledge in this school.

In this regard, mention may be made of Sufyaan Soori, Abu Hanifa (the spiritual head of the Hanafi sect when is the main branch of Sunnis), Qazi Sukooni and Qazi Abul Bakhtari. These are the

famous words of Abu Hanifa:

لَوْلَا السَّنَتَانِ لَهَلَكَ التُّعْبَانُ

If those two years (referring to the time when he obtained training from Imam Sadiq (a.s.)) had not been there, No'man would have been destroyed.¹

In Shia history, the manners and methods of the two Imams (a.s.) resemble each other so much that this era is called the Baqirain period or the Sadiqain period. The compilation of narrations recorded in our books from these two Imams exceeds the sum total of all the traditions from the Prophet (s.a.w.a.) and the other Imams (a.s.).

The True Religion

Since the Shias have come to be known as Ja'fari and the sect is introduced as headed by Imam Sadiq (a.s.), it is necessary to give clarification in this respect. At times, due to misinterpretation of history, some people think the Shias are in the same rank as the four Sunni sects and Imam Ja'far Sadiq (a.s.) is a personality like Abu Hanifa, Ahmad Ibn Hanbal, Malik Ibn Anas and Shafeii. Some simpletons who wish to turn towards unification of Islam and return to the pristine religion express that we should return to the same religion that prevailed during the time of the Holy Prophet (s.a.w.a.), when there was no origin of these five persons. This is a totally wrong and absurd idea. The Shias do not believe that a new sect (other than Islam) has been invented in the second

¹ Kitabul Irshad written by Sheikh Mufid, p. 254; Fusulul Muhimmah, p. 204; Al-Manaaqib of Ibn Shahre Aashob, vol. 4, p. 247

¹ Siratul A'immatil Ithna Ashara, vol. 2, p. 248

century Hijri, entrusting the leadership to Imam Ja'far Sadiq (a.s.). This may be more applicable to the Sunnis whose leaders did not see the initial period of Islam and their jurisprudence was formulated with a gap of more than a century. The term 'shia' has its roots from the era of the Holy Prophet (s.a.w.a.) as is evident in history while the other sects are devoid of this excellence (which proves their wrong path of understanding religion). In order to present evidence for this claim, we produce just one of numerous examples, in this lesson. Jalaaluddin Suyuti, a reputed Sunni scholar has authored a famous commentary by the name of Al-Durrul Manthoor wherein he discusses this verse of the Noble Qur'an:

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَعَمِلُوا الصَّالِحَاتِ أُولَٰئِكَ هُمْ خَيْرُ الْبَرِّ.

Surely those who believe and do good, they are the best of men.¹

He quotes Ibn Abbas, the noted commentator of Islamic world narrating that the Prophet (s.a.w.a.) addressed Imam Ali (a.s.) after the revelation of this verse and remarked:

أَنْتَ وَشِيعَتُكَ يَوْمَ الْقِيَامَةِ رَاضِينَ مَرْضِيَّيْنِ.

You and your Shias will be happy and satisfied on the day of Judgement.

In this way, we see that Islam and Shiaism are born simultaneously

and Shiaism is not an offshoot of Islam but Islam itself.¹

But the reason for our sect to be called Ja'fari has already been explained in the previous chapter of Imam Baqir (a.s.). In the early part of history, from the time of Imam Ali (a.s.) to Imam Sajjad (a.s.), the power of the Umayyid dynasty and the repeated confrontations that took place, left no time for collecting and compiling the foundation of the rich culture of Shias. But during the era of these two Imams (a.s.), political conditions allowed easy propagation of the fundamentals of Islamic culture, hence the name Ja'fari. This is entirely different from saying that Shias came into being during the Imamate of Imam Sadiq (a.s.).

Shias and Islam

The fact is that Shiaism is the true method and path of Islam. Our leaders after the Holy Prophet (s.a.w.a.) are the personalities who sourced knowledge from that divine spring only and have been performing the duties of leadership after the Prophet(s.a.w.a.)'s demise till date. Imam Sadiq (a.s.) has been the source of the greatest services to Islam during his 34 years of Imamate. It is crystal clear that if his tremendous and exhaustive collection of sayings and guidelines in diverse fields of religion and society did not exist, Islam would not enjoy the universality and comprehensiveness which it does today. The treasure house of sciences and facts would have remained undisclosed. Today, in the world of jurisprudence, Fiqhe Ja'fari is viewed as the most

¹ Imam Baqir (a.s.) and Imam Sadiq (a.s.) have always reiterated that whatever we say is nothing but words of Allah and His messenger (s.a.w.a.). For details, refer to Ayaanush Shia, vol. 4, p. 34.

accurate basis of law.

His Worship

Imam (a.s.) Sadiq (a.s.), like his forefathers, was a mine of excellences. He had such depth in worship that Maalik Ibn Anas, Imam of the Malikis (one of the four Sunni sects) says:

I would generally observe him in one of these three conditions: Either offering prayers (namaz), observing fast or reciting the holy Qur'an.

The Importance of Namaz

He was so firm in the worship of Allah that even on his death bed, while breathing his last, he called in his near ones and addressed them thus:

إِنَّهُ لَا يَنَالُ شَفَاعَتَنَا مَنْ اسْتَخَفَّ بِالصَّلَاةِ

Surely, he will not reach our intercession, the one who takes namaz lightly.¹

The Patience of Imam (a.s.)

He was the possessor of untold reservoirs of patience and trust in Allah. When his beloved son Ismail, who excelled in worship and virtue, passed away due to illness, his followers observed that Imam (a.s.) did not suffer from excessive sadness or pain on account of his demise. When the reason for this was asked from him, he replied:

“How could I feel restless on his death when the truthful messenger (s.a.w.a.) has said:

إِنِّي مَيِّتٌ وَإِيَّاكُمْ

Surely I will die and so will you all.”¹

Maintaining Relations

Like his predecessors, he always aided the needy. In disguise, he would carry a heavy load of bread, meat and money on his back and deliver it to the poor of Madinah.

It is enough exposition of his boundless knowledge that hundreds of treatises and scripts exist even today in many areas of scientific research from some of his students like Jabir Ibn Hayyaan. This clearly elucidates that they were the outcomes of the fruits of learning in the school of Imam Sadiq (a.s.). Farid-e-Wajdi in the encyclopedia of the fourteenth century, vol 3, page 110, Sayyed Hebatuddin Shehristani on page 53 of Al-Dalaael wal Masaael and Ibn Nadim in his Fehrist, page 514, have made references to a part of the scientific works of the students of Imam (a.s.), particularly Jabir Ibn Hayyaan in the field of chemistry. They have pointed out that Jabir, in most of his books and treatises, has begun his chapters with the words such as:

قَالَ لِي جَعْفَرٌ رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُ - أَلْقَى عَلَيَّ جَعْفَرٌ - حَدَّثَنِي مَوْلَايَ جَعْفَرٌ رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُ

¹ Wasaael al-Shiah, vol. 3, p. 253, Ch. 75, narrating from Oyoona-o-Akhbaar al-Reza (a.s.)

¹ Al-Kaafi, vol. 3, p. 270

أَخَذْتُ هَذَا الْعِلْمَ مِنْ سَيِّدِي جَعْفَرِ بْنِ مُحَمَّدٍ سَيِّدِ أَهْلِ زَمَانِهِ
و.....

Ja'far (a.s.) told me – narrated for me my master Ja'far (a.s.) - I took this knowledge from my master, Ja'far Ibn Muhammad (a.s.), the master of people of his time.

In this way, he has shown that Imam Sadiq (a.s.) has been the source of all these sciences.

The Greater Sins

The contemporaries of Imam (a.s.) derived maximum benefit from him in all points of views and in all areas of sciences. For example, one of the jurisprudents, a religious authority of the time in Basra, by the name of Amr Ibn Ubaid had the honour of meeting Imam (a.s.) and requested him to comment on a verse of the Qur'an, i.e. Sura Nisa (4): verse 31:

إِنْ تَجْتَنِبُوا كَبَائِرَ مَا تُنْهَوْنَ عَنْهُ.

“If you keep away from the major sins which you have been prohibited.”

He asked Imam (a.s.) to recount the major sins from Qur'an to him. Imam (a.s.) started speaking with such mastery and knowledge, as if he knew the question beforehand and had prepared the answer. He enumerated 24 major sins based on Qur'anic verses and famous traditions of the Holy Prophet (s.a.w.a.). The scholar was totally bewildered. While taking leave of the Imam's (a.s.) house, he was

heard commenting:

هَذَا مَنْ سَلَبَ تَرَاثُكُمْ وَنَازَعَكُمْ فِي الْفَضْلِ وَالْعِلْمِ.

May he be destroyed who has deprived you of your heritage (the one who has usurped the right of leadership) and disputed with you in knowledge and excellence.¹

It is appropriate to know that fleeing from war, losing hope in the mercy of Allah, being cursed by father and mother, false witness, leaving namaz, breaking promises and cutting off relations with one's relatives, all these have been reckoned by Imam (a.s.) as being among the major sins. The last of the major sins which was mentioned by Imam (a.s.) was heresy and quoting the Holy Prophet (s.a.w.a.), he said:

مَنْ تَبَسَّمَ فِي وَجْهِهِ مُبْتَدِعٌ فَقَدْ أَعَانَ عَلَى هَدْمِ دِينِهِ

Anyone who smiles at a person who introduces something new or heretical in religion, has indeed helped him in the destruction of his religion.²

Training of Preachers

Among the important works of Imam (a.s.) was the training of a number of his experienced students for discussion and debate with the leaders of different sects and religions. At the top of the list was Imam's (a.s.) famous young companion by the name of Hisham Ibn Hakam. In this way, the light of Islam became evident

¹ Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 47, p. 216, H. 4 narrating from Al-Manaaqeb

² Ibid.

on one hand and on the other, the deviation that others intended to spread and propagate was dealt with. These students would first learn the method of debate and argument from Imam (a.s.). After every debate they would normally report to Imam (a.s.) so that probable defects could be rectified. Their presence in the company of Imam (a.s.) and observation of his specific debates with the scholars and believers of other religions too was a significant factor in their learning of this important task. The Imam (a.s.) never faced a particular group only in such discussions. Rather, he would discuss and debate with different groups such as unbelievers, polytheists, atheists, fatalists and the Tafwizi (who believe God has no control left). But since the students did not possess the comprehensiveness of knowledge of Imam (a.s.), hence depending upon their interest and talent, they would each specialize in a particular field.

Martyrdom

The Abbasid Caliphs took the reins from the Umayyid. After gaining control over the people, they adopted a similar method and policy as the Umayyid but with greater harshness towards the household of the Prophet (s.a.w.a.) and their Shia followers. Particularly, during the rule of Mansoor, a strict watch was maintained on Imam (a.s.) who was forcibly called from Madinah to the administrative headquarters several times. On numerous occasions, Mansoor also ordered the assassination of Imam (a.s.). But his majestic presence and his personality created such awe in Mansoor that he gave up the idea. But, his jealousy of the Imam (a.s.) increased exponentially due to Imam's (a.s.) knowledge, social and Islamic stature. He finally ordered that Imam (a.s.) be

poisoned.

Imam (a.s.) was martyred by the poison given by Muhammad Ibn Sulaiman, Mansoor's governor in Madinah on 15th Rajab in the year 148 Hijri at the age of 65 years. He was laid to rest in the graveyard of Baqi besides the other three Imams (a.s.).

Lessons from His Life

Imam (a.s.) Sadiq's (a.s.) Imamatus lasted a period of 34 years during which he trained his Shias to overcome adversities in reaching one's goal. He also showed that no movement or campaign could survive unless it bears cultural roots and depth. Hence, every opportunity must be utilized in making the movement deep rooted. Imam (a.s.), in his Imamatus, made the Shia Islam so rich with the basics and established such scientific and cultural roots that 14 centuries of attacks against this religion with the Shias in minority and all the restrictions upon its leaders have not been able to eradicate it. Rather, day by day, these circumstances themselves have been effective in the exaltation of Islam and Shiaism.

Lesson No. 14

Imam Musa al-Kazim (a.s.)

أَتِيحَتْ بَعْدَهُ مُوسَى فِتْنَةً عِبَاءُ حَنْدِسٍ لِأَنَّ خَيْطَ فَرْضِي لَا يَنْقَطِعُ
وَحُجَّتِي لَا تَخْفَى.....

Appointed after him (Imam Sadiq (a.s.)) Musa (in whose time) there will be a severe calamity because the path of My obedience will not be cut off and My Hujjat will not be hidden.¹

Name	: Hazrat Musa Ibn Ja'far (a.s.)
Father's name	: Imam Ja'far Sadiq (a.s.)
Mother's name	: Hamidah Khatoon
Date of Birth	: 3 rd Safar/ 7 th Safar, 128 A. H.
Place of Birth	: Abwaa
Kuniyyat	: Abu Ibrahim, Abul Hasan al-Awwal, Abul Hasan al-Maazi
Titles	: Zaaahir, Kazim, Abd as-Saleh, etc.
Age	: 55 years
Martyrdom	: 25th Rajab, 183 A. H.
Buried	: Kazmain, Iraq

Bani Abbas

As mentioned in the previous chapter, the Abbasids followed a path similar to the Umayyids or even worse. The very people who played a major role in overthrowing the Bani Umayyah and fought in support of the Bani Abbas were regretting their decision.

The new caliphs began oppressing the divine leaders of Islam (the Holy Imams (a.s.)) with greater intensity. During his life time, Imam Kazim (a.s.) witnessed the reign of four caliphs namely Mansoor, Mohammad Mahdi, Moosa al-Hadi and Haroon Rashid. He faced a lot of suffering because of them and passed a large part of his life in the prisons of Muhammad Mahdi. Moreover, he remained in the prisons of Basra and Baghdad on the orders of Haroon Rashid, the powerful and pleasure seeking Abbasid caliph. Nonetheless, during the 35 years of his Imamate, Imam (a.s.) was under severe control and watch of government.

Love for Imam (a.s.)

The matter which increased the jealousy of the Abbasid caliphs, particularly Haroon towards Imam (a.s.) was the great love, affection and reputation he enjoyed among the different groups of people in the society. The caliphs observed that their pomp and position did nothing in winning over the people not realizing that this affection of the people towards Imam (a.s.) was a divine endowment.

Characteristic of Imamate

When Imam Sadiq (a.s.) wanted to speak regarding the qualities of his son Imam Musa Kazim (a.s.), he would say:

¹ Hadees-e-Lauh

فِيهِ عِلْمُ الْحُكْمِ وَالْفَهْمُ وَالسَّخَاءُ وَالْبَعْرِفَةُ بِبَايَحْتَابِ النَّاسِ إِلَيْهِ
فِيمَا اخْتَلَفُوا فِيهِ مِنْ أَمْرِ دِينِهِمْ وَفِيهِ حُسْنُ الْخُلُقِ وَحُسْنُ الْجَوَارِ
وَهُوَ بَابٌ مِنْ أَبْوَابِ اللَّهِ عَزَّ وَجَلَّ.

In him is the knowledge of judgement, understanding, generosity and cognition due to which the people need him in solving disputes in religious affairs and he possesses a good conduct. He is a secured neighbour and a gate from the gates of (recognizing) Allah, Mighty and Majestic be He.¹

Haroon tells his son Mamoon about his awareness towards the divine position of Imam (a.s.) in these words:

هَذَا إِمَامُ النَّاسِ وَحُجَّةُ اللَّهِ عَلَى خَلْقِهِ وَخَلِيفَتُهُ عَلَى عِبَادِهِ.

This is the leader of the people and the Proof of Allah upon His creatures and His Caliph upon His servants.²

Safeguarding Shias

While Imam (a.s.) passed a greater portion of his life in strict custody and vigilance of the authorities, he took care of the affairs of the Muslims and his Shias with his innovative plans. Imam (a.s.) had some Shia agents in the government.

¹ Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 48, p. 12, Ch. 3, H. 1, narrating from Oyyoon-o-Akhbaar al-Reza (a.s.)

² Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 48, p. 131, Ch. 6, H. 4, narrating from Oyyoon-o-Akhbaar al-Reza (a.s.)

Through this method, he gathered information about the plans and schemes of the rulers and also provided facilities to his friends (who were always subjected to harassment and atrocities by the authorities for they were accused of being Shia). The most famous of these agents was Ali Ibn Yaqteen, the prime minister of Haroon. This part of Imam's (a.s.) life teaches us that within legitimate limits we should make use of means at our disposal to achieve our goals. By putting forward baseless arguments, we should not overlook the group possessing power, lose all positions under various pretexts and surrender all of them in favour of blood thirsty enemies.

Helping the Believers

The brief letters left by Imam (a.s.) in the scrolls of history addressed to the government authorities indicate the use of various elements and his hidden influence at different levels of the Abbasid government. For instance, in a letter written to the governor of Rey province advising and recommending him the case of one of the Shias (who was heavily taxed illegitimately and who could not afford to pay it), the Imam (a.s.) wrote:

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ. اَعْلَمَنَّ أَنَّ لِلَّهِ تَعَالَى تَحْتَ عَرْشِهِ ظِلًّا لَا
يَسْكُنُهُ مَنْ أَسْدَى إِلَى أَخِيهِ مَعْرُوفًا أَوْ نَفْسَ عَنْهُ كُرْبَةً أَوْ أَدْخَلَ
عَلَى قَلْبِهِ سُرُورًا. وَهَذَا أَخُوكَ وَالسَّلَامُ.

In the Name of Allah the Beneficent the Merciful. Know that there is a shadow under the throne of Allah (arsh) whereunder none can reside except the one who has

either rendered a goodness to his brother or removed from him a grief and made him joyous and happy. And this person is your brother. Was-salaam.¹

A careful study of the text of the letter which apparently makes no mention of either the addressee or the writer nor the person who is recommended, indicates the precautions which Imam (a.s.) took to conceal the personalities of his contacts in the caliphate. This was meant to prevent all possible problems for them. Naturally, the presence of these figures in the higher echelons of government could by itself result in the failure of the plots hatched by the Abbasids to assassinate Imam (a.s.). It would result not only in the safety of Imam's (a.s.) life but the people could continue to benefit from this ocean of knowledge and wisdom.

Worship in Prison

A study of Imam's (a.s.) manner and conduct in prison teaches us valuable lessons. Imam (a.s.) utilized this opportunity in uplifting his soul through worship of Allah in such way that it astonished everyone. Fazl Ibn Rabi, one of the jailers, has described the period of Imam's (a.s.) confinement in his own words which is recorded in the book 'Aayaan al-Shia'. He speaks about the magnificence of his spirit and his profound inclination in prayers and prostration before the Almighty Allah.

This fact is also reflected in the statement of the sister of Sendi Ibn Shahek, the last jailor of Imam (a.s.). So impressed was she by the spiritual state and the worship of Imam (a.s.) that she would

¹ Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 48, p. 174, Ch. 7, H. 16, narrating from the book Qazaa-o-Hoqooq al-Momineen.

repeatedly say:

خَابَ قَوْمٌ تَعَرَّضُوا لِهَذَا الرَّجُلِ.

What a loser is the community that stretches its atrocious and cruel hands towards this great man.

Anyhow, the 35 year period of Imam's (a.s.) leadership passed in this manner where he would not spare an effort in serving Islam and finding ways and means to safeguard it. When Haroon would request him for counsel, he would not only comply with the request but also give statements replete with an ocean of meaning:

مَا مِنْ شَيْءٍ تَرَاهُ عَيْنُكَ إِلَّا فِيهِ مَوْعِظَةٌ

Your eye does not see anything but in it is an admonishment.¹

But it needs an open eye and an attentive ear to take advice from this preaching.

To rein in the arrogance of Haroon, he would write to him:

**إِنَّهُ لَنْ يَنْقُضِيَ عَنِّي يَوْمٌ مِنَ الْبَلَاءِ إِلَّا أَنْقَضَى مَعَهُ عَنْكَ مَعَهُ يَوْمٌ
مِنَ الرَّخَاءِ حَتَّى نَقْضِيَ جَمِيعًا إِلَى يَوْمٍ لَيْسَ لَهُ انْقِضَاءٌ هُنَاكَ
يُخَسِرُ فِيهِ الْبُطْلُونَ.**

Know that my hard days and your days of pleasure pass

¹ Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 71, p. 324, H. 14, narrating from Amaali of Saduq (a.r.)

*away concurrently and we shall come to an eternal period
when the wrongdoers will be in heavy loss.¹*

This is a sign of the elevated and liberal spirit of a free man who is apparently in prison but talks firmly to a powerful person like Haroon. This teaches us the freedom of personality, spiritual power and firmness of faith.

Importance of Religious Knowledge

To bring the Muslims closer to the Holy Qur'an (the illuminator of the path) and its sciences, he wrote in his will:

تَفَقَّهُوا فِي دِينِ اللَّهِ فَإِنَّ الْفَقْهَ مِفْتَاحُ الْبَصِيرَةِ وَتَسَامُ الْعِبَادَةِ وَ
السَّبَبُ إِلَى الْمَنَازِلِ الرَّفِيعَةِ وَالرُّتَبِ الْجَلِيلَةِ فِي الدِّينِ وَالدُّنْيَا وَ
فَضْلُ الْفَقِيهِ عَلَى الْعَابِدِ كَفَضْلِ الشَّمْسِ عَلَى الْكَوَاكِبِ وَمَنْ لَمْ
يَتَفَقَّهُ فِي دِينِهِ لَمْ يَرْضَ اللَّهُ لَهُ عَمَلًا.

Acquire deep knowledge in religion. For, deep knowledge is the key to insight and the perfection of worship and a means to reach and attain the exaltation in religion and the world. The superiority of the learned scholar over the worshipper is like the superiority of the sun over the stars. Anybody who fails to acquire deep knowledge in his religion, Allah will not be satisfied with his deeds.²

Martyrdom

Finally, on Friday, the 25th of Rajab in the year 183 A.H., he bid farewell to the world on account of the poison given by Sendi Ibn Shahek in the Baghdad jail at the behest of Haroon leaving behind the Shias and lovers of truth and freedom in tears, grief and sorrow.

¹ Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 48, p. 148, Ch. 6, H. 22, narrating from Kashf al-Ghummah of Marhum Irbili (r.a.)

² Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 10, p. 427, Ch. 16, narrating from Tohaf al-Oqool,

Lesson No. 15

Imam Ali Reza (a.s.)

وَيْلٌ لِلْمُفْتَرِينَ الْجَاحِدِينَ عِنْدَ انْقِضَاءِ مُدَّةِ مُوسَى. عَبْدِي وَ
حَبِيبِي وَخَيْرِي فِي عَلِيٍّ وَلِيِّي وَنَاصِرِي.

**Woe unto the false accusers and repudiators of Ali,
My friend and My helper (who will take charge) after
period of Musa (a.s.), My servant, My beloved and My
chosen one.¹**

Name	: Hazrat Ali Ibn Musa (a.s.)
Father's name	: Imam Musa Kazim (a.s.)
Mother's name	: Khayzoraan, Arwaa, Najmah, Tahirah
Date of Birth	: 11 th Zilqad, 148 A. H.
Place of Birth	: Madinah Munawwara
Kuniyyat	: Abul Hasan
Titles	: Reza, Saabir, Zaki, Waafi, etc.
Age	: 55 years
Martyrdom	: 17 th Safar, 203 A. H.
Buried	: Mashhad, Iran

On Thursday, the 11th of Zilqad, 148 A.H., a child was born in the house of Imam Musa al-Kazim (a.s.) by his wife Tahirah, in

Madinah. He was named Ali. His childhood and youth was spent under the guardianship of his great and noble father, who was the inheritor of the holy status of Imamat.

He became Imam on the demise of his pious father in the year 183 A.H. and started looking after the affairs of the Shias. Imam Ali Ibn Musa (a.s.) (popularly known by his title Reza) faced the reign of three Abbasid caliphs in his Imamat of 20 years. Ten years of Haroon as caliph, five of Ameen and five years of Mamoon.

The period of his Imamat can be divided into three distinct parts.

First Period

During the Caliphate of Haroon for ten years, the conditions created for Imam (a.s.) after the martyrdom of Imam Musa al-Kazim (a.s.) were similar to those conditions prevailing for Imam Zainul Aabedeen (a.s.) after the event of Aashoora. During this period, the government of Haroon had increased its vigilance on Imam (a.s.). The Shias of Imam (a.s.) were also put to intense surveillance by the ruler.

For instance, Haroon ordered to Humaid Ibn Qahtaba, one of his agents to behead sixty Shias in a single night. It was during this period that Imam Reza's (a.s.) brother Abdullah Aftas was imprisoned.

Second Period

This period was of eight years, i.e., after the death of Haroon till the acceptance of Imam (a.s.) as Mamoon's heir apparent. This period is similar to that of the 5th and 6th Imams (a.s.). During this time, there were uprisings in every corner of the Islamic empire,

¹ Hadees-e-Lauh, al-Kaafi, vol. 1, p. 527, H. 3

which greatly perturbed the ruling party in addition to the power struggle between Ameen and Mamoon. Imam (a.s.) was provided some freedom. From among the most important revolts of Alawi Sadat, was that of Muhammad-e-Deebaj in Madinah, Muhammad Ibn Ibrahim and Abul Saraya. They revolted against the tyrannical government of the Abbasids. These reflected the shaky position of the Abbasid rule and the strength of the opposition.

Third Period

The period as heir apparent of Imam Reza (a.s.) lasted for 18 months from the time of the acceptance of Mamoon's proposal for the post till the martyrdom of Imam (a.s.). This period was full of varied difficulties and we will elaborate on it in due course.

After the period of hardships and restrictions of Haroon, Imam (a.s.) got enough time to further the works done by his predecessors, Imam Baqir (a.s.) and Imam Sadiq (a.s.). He strived to divulge the truths of Islam. Ample traditions on various topics related by Imam (a.s.) are still found in books showing his efforts in this regard. Ultimately, Mamoon killed his brother Ameen and hung the severed head on the door of his palace. He then awarded prizes to his army officers in front of it for killing his own brother. After this incident, Mamoon felt that the worst danger was from the followers of Imam Ali (a.s.).

Iranians who had occupied key positions in the government by the dint of their intellect and skill, even the highest position of chief minister, had hidden love for Ali (a.s.) in their hearts. Since, Imam Reza (a.s.) was successor to Imamat, he obviously was the recipient of all this love and affection.

The only alternative to suppress the diverse movements which posed a danger to Mamoon's government was to gain the favour of Imam Reza (a.s.). He was well aware that the agitations against his rule would ultimately end in the favour of the Household of Prophet (s.a.w.a.). Thus, he played a trick. He wrote a letter to Imam (a.s.) inviting him to take over the seat of caliphate. This decision was taken in consultation of his Iranian minister, Fazl Ibn Sahl. Although this was an apparently respectful request but the authorities had been strictly ordered to make him accept. He was actually forced to leave Hejaz for Khorasan (though it looked as if he was free to decide). Throughout the route, Mamoon had cunningly arranged the journey in stately splendor. Maybe he wanted to project that Imam (a.s.) had reached an agreement with him, and so degrade Imam's (a.s.) personality.

Aware of the guile, Imam (a.s.) wanted to make it clear that he had not undertaken the journey willingly but had been forced to do so. So, he did not take his family members along with him. It thus became evident for the wise that if he was going with an intention to rule, he would have taken his near ones with him.

During the course of his long journey, Imam (a.s.) passed through different cities and gave speeches according to the prevailing circumstances. Listening to his sermons, people were attracted to both the Islamic teachings and also his outstanding personality. They saw that words of wisdom flowed from this divine personality. As such, the plan of Mamoon had not only failed but had actually worked against him. In Nishapur, Imam (a.s.) related the tradition (famous as Silsilatus Zahab) before a huge crowd. He narrates from his forefathers (a.s.), from the Holy Prophet

(s.a.w.a.), from Jibraeel given by Allah.

كَلِمَةُ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا اللَّهُ حِصْنِي فَمَنْ دَخَلَ حِصْنِي أَمِنَ مِنْ عَذَابِي

The words 'laa ilaha illallah' (there is no God except Allah) is My fort, then one who enters My fort is safe from My chastisement.

Imam (a.s.) introduced Allah as the only stronghold of refuge, destroying the superficial glory and power of kings and emperors like Mamoon. He further explained this fortification by regard for the divine guides.

بِشْرُوطِهَا وَأَنَا مِنْ شُرُوطِهَا

*But it (the benefit of divine protection) has conditions.
And I am (one) of those conditions.*

In short, belief in Tauheed has no benefit without accepting the Imam of the time. This struck a second blow on the authority of Mamoon.

Imam (a.s.) reached Marv on 10th Shawwal 201 Hijri. Mamoon and his key people came a good few miles to meet and welcome Imam (a.s.) and brought him to the city in great honour and majesty. After a few days of reception, Mamoon declared his intention to Imam (a.s.). First, he offered the seat of caliphate which Imam strongly refused. One can pose a question, why did Imam refuse? Do Shias not claim that Imamatus and Caliphate is the prerogative of the Imams (a.s.)?

A quick glance into history and the motives of this political move

will clarify the matter for us. Is it logical for a person like Mamoon who killed his own brother for the post to give it up in favour of the opposition leader? Obviously, every wise person will realize this was a political stunt. Would the caliphate of the Imam (a.s.) not cause an uprising among the officers, governors and the rich who are habituated to oppression, plunder and suppression of the truth over a very long period of time? They would clearly not remain silent.

What a surprise to see the successor to Mansoor and Haroon trying to accord respect to the successor of the Imams, Imam Baqir (a.s.), Imam Sadiq (a.s.) and Imam Kazim (a.s.), all of whom were poisoned by these evil caliphs.

The truth was far different. He wanted to defame the holy personality of Imam (a.s.). After Imam's (a.s.) acceptance, he would foment disturbances through his accomplices, then return to the scene as a reformer and overthrow Imam (a.s.), claiming that divine caliphs do not possess the ability to lead the society.

But he was unaware that successor from the Prophet's Household (a.s.) was aware of his nefarious intentions and was not willing to accept the caliphate.

Since Mamoon had been defeated once more, he called upon Imam (a.s.) to accept the proposal of heir apparent (ولي عهد). Imam (a.s.) did not accept this proposal. But, Mamoon insisted to the point of compulsion and distress.

He now planned that giving Imam (a.s.) a place in his court would extinguish the flames of revolution, especially of the Alawi Saadaat. As a matter of fact, on seeing their representative in court,

they would fall silent. Another probability would be that a few emotional people would look superficially into the problem without going to its bottom and form a wrong opinion of Shias and their leaders. They would disobey Imam (a.s.) under the excuse that he has compromised with the unjust government. Then, either Imam (a.s.) would lose followers or silence them and it would be very easy to destroy him (a.s.). Mamoon would achieve absolute control over the entire Islamic nation.

When Imam (a.s.) realized that there was no escape from accepting the offer, he put forth a seemingly simple condition. Imam (a.s.) would not interfere with current affairs like appointment and dismissal of governors, political and military affairs. As Mamoon had become impressed by Imam's (a.s.) acceptance, he readily accepted the condition without realizing that this was indication enough that the acceptance was under duress. It was meaningless that he accepts the heir apparenacy and stays away from the work of the government.

Anyhow, the agreement written personally by Mamoon was sent to Imam (a.s.). Imam (a.s.) too wrote something behind it and quoted a verse in the third sentence:

يَعْلَمُ خَائِنَةَ الْأَعْيُنِ وَمَا تُخْفِي الصُّدُورُ.

He knows the stealthy looks and that which the breasts conceal.¹

Writing of the verse is a clear indication that Imam (a.s.) was aware of Mamoon's treachery. Finally the settlement took place

and Imam (a.s.) was placed as heir apparent in Marv.

Not before long, Mamoon realized his defeat. The revolutionary movements had not subsided and Imam (a.s.) was still ruling the hearts of people. The government had not earned any brownie points. He did not keep silent. He entered into a new kind of battle. As Mamoon himself was learned and his court was always host to scholars and orators of different religions and fields, he thought that debates of these people with Imam (a.s.) on various scientific and religious subjects would put a blot on the knowledgeable personality of Imam (a.s.). He had already introduced translated foreign ideologies which were new and unfamiliar to Islamic society for confusing the Muslim mind and taking undue advantage for himself. Now, he wanted to use his previous work in crushing the aura of Imam (a.s.). He arranged big gatherings and invited Imam (a.s.) for debates. The gatherings grew pace and Imam (a.s.) presented a new facet every time. He spoke with Christians in their language, the same with Jews, fire worshippers, Sabe'een, etc.

Soon the aides of Mamoon realized that he had failed once again and the divine knowledge of Imam (a.s.) became more evident than before. Another incident of this period served a severe blow to Mamoon. In order to show that he was on good terms with Imam (a.s.), it was suggested to lead Eidul Fitr prayers. Initially Imam (a.s.) refused. But, when Mamoon insisted, Imam (a.s.) accepted with the condition that he should be allowed to go to the place of prayer as Holy Prophet (s.a.w.a.) used to go. Imam (a.s.) came out of the house dressed in white and while reciting takbeer, he proceeded outside the city. On the way, Muslims joined this gathering in groups and the cry 'Allahu Akbar' resounded in every

¹ Surah Ghaafir (40), Verse 19

nook and corner. The advisers of Mamoon warned him to think of a remedy quickly for it was likely that after the prayers and sermon of Imam (a.s.), there could be public discontent and uprising against his tyrannical government. Mamoon tactfully called Imam (a.s.) back from halfway. This incident took place in the month of Shawwal 202 A.H. Mamoon became insecure and frightened seeing that he was committing harakiri and he gradually came to the conclusion to kill Imam (a.s.). On the 17th day of Safar, 203 Hijri, he poisoned Imam Reza (a.s.) and left a permanent shameful stain of pure blood on his clothes by this cowardly act.

Even in his last hours, Imam (a.s.) looked after his near ones. When he saw that his servants and companions had not eaten food and were lamenting his serious illness (due to the poison), he ordered his servant Yaseer to serve food and with great difficulty he himself sat besides his companions. Moreover, he ordered that women should also be served with food separately. It was after this serving of food that Imam (a.s.) fainted, fell on one side and expired.

Imam (a.s.) Meets Everyone

Whenever the table was laid, he sat with different groups of people such as slaves, servants and guests and when someone took objection to this, he would say:

إِنَّ الرَّبَّ تَبَارَكَ وَتَعَالَى وَاحِدٌ وَالْأُمُّ وَاحِدَةٌ وَالْأَبُّ وَاحِدٌ وَالْجَزَاءُ
بِالْأَعْمَالِ.

Surely Our Exalted Lord is One and our mother is one

and our father is one and the reward is only connected with the actions of man.¹

In order to know about the affection of Imam (a.s.) towards worship, it is not out of place to mention this incident. Imam (a.s.) sent a gift to one of the Shia poets of the time, viz, Debel Khuzaai. This gift was a cloak made of fur which he himself had worn. Imam (a.s.) gifted this cloak to him since in this dress, Imam (a.s.) had prayed for a thousand nights and in each night a thousand rak'at namaz and finished reciting the Qur'an for a thousand times.

¹ Al-Kaafi, vol. 8, p. 230, H. 296

Lesson No. 16

Imam Mohammad Taqi (a.s.)

لَا سِرَّ لَهُ بِسُحَّهِ ابْنِهِ وَ خَلِيفَتِهِ مِنْ بَعْدِهِ وَ وَارِثِ عَلَيْهِ فَهُوَ
مَعْدُنُ عَلِيٍّ وَ مَوْضِعُ سِرِّي وَ حُجَّتِي عَلَى خَلْقِي.

“Surely, I will make him (Imam Reza (a.s.)) happy through his son Mohammad who is his successor after him and the inheritor of his knowledge. He is the treasure house of My knowledge and the stronghold of My secrets and My proof upon My creatures.”¹

Name	: Hazrat Mohammad Ibn Ali (a.s.)
Father's name	: Hazrat Imam Ali Reza (a.s.)
Mother's name	: Sabika, Khayzran, Durrah
Date of Birth	: 10 th Rajab, 195 A. H.
Place of Birth	: Madinah Munawwarah
Kuniyyat	: Abu Jafar al-Saani
Titles	: Jawad, Taqi
Age	: 25 years
Martyrdom	: Last day of Zilqad, 220 A. H.
Buried	: Kazmain

Imam Taqi (a.s.) was born on the eve of Friday, 10th of Rajab 195

A.H. His mother's name was Sabika. He spent his first 8 years with his holy father, Imam Reza (a.s.). In 203 A.H., after the martyrdom of Imam Reza (a.s.), he succeeded him as the Imam. His agnomen (Kuniyyat) was 'Abu Jafar.'

The concern of the Imam being a minor had never appeared earlier in the chain of Imamate. Hence this became an issue for the first time in the case of Imam Taqi (a.s.). On one hand, there was a group of people who questioned how Allah, the Almighty could grant the exalted status of Imamate to a young child and hand over the reins of guidance of the community to him. We can realise this matter by observing the questions which were raised about the Imam (a.s.) during his father's time. During the period of Imam Ali Reza (a.s.), those who were enquiring about his Imamate at a young age were told to consider and study the appointment of Isa (a.s.) who was raised to the position of Prophethood while he was still in the cradle. Imam Ali Reza (a.s.) indicated this fact in a simple sentence saying,

إِنَّا أَهْلُ بَيْتٍ يَتَوَارَثُ أَصَاغِرُنَا عَنْ أَكَابِرِنَا الْقُدَّةُ بِالْقُدَّةِ.

“We are a family in which our young inherit each and everything from their elders.”¹

On the other hand, Mamoon who suffered heavy defeats in confronting the learned personality of Imam Reza (a.s.) thought that after his martyrdom, there would be no further obstacles in his path. When the message of the Imamate of Imam Taqi (a.s.) reached him, considering the young age of the new Imam (a.s.), he

¹ Hadees-e-Lauh

¹ Al-Kaafi, vol. 1, p. 320, H. 2

considered repeating his wicked plan (which he had carried out against Imam Reza (a.s.)) to crush the holy personality of Imam Taqi (a.s.). However history witnessed how Mamoon had to face disgrace in his plans yet again. Mamoon organised for group discussions and debates by calling known scholars of the era such as Yahya Ibn Aktham and instigated them to pose difficult questions to Imam (a.s.). But when these scholars were confronted by the Imam (a.s.) regarding their own questions and the various facets thereof, they were bewildered and left the gathering with their heads hanging in shame.

When Yahya Ibn Aktham was the Chief Justice, he, on Mamoon's instructions, sought the opinion of the Imam (a.s.) about a person who hunts while in the state of Ehram. Imam (a.s.) while explaining the eleven aspects of this question, asked him as to which aspect he wanted. On hearing this, Yahya Ibn Aktham was stunned. In a state of visible discomfort, his helplessness was obvious to all. After everybody had left, Mamoon requested Imam (a.s.) to answer the question from all the aspects and the same was done by the Imam (a.s.) in great detail.¹

Many such incidents had made Mamoon's ego bite the dust. Imam's tremendous knowledge had made such an impression on Mamoon's mind that whenever anyone would speak ill of Imam (a.s.) for any reason and bring forward the matter of the young age of the Imam (a.s.) as an excuse, Mamoon would rebuke them saying, "He is more knowledgeable than any of you and more acquainted with the Shariat of Allah and the Sunnah of the Prophet than you. He is better versed than all of you about the Quran. If

you desire you can test him, and if you find him as I have described, then accept my word."

In order to keep a close eye on Imam (a.s.), despite stiff opposition of his advisors, Mamoon gave the hand of his daughter Ummul Fazl to him so that he may be aware of the activities in Imam's (a.s.) house. Thus, despite lack of any apparent external pressure, Imam (a.s.) was kept under strict surveillance. The uneasiness that Imam (a.s.) experienced from this forceful living can be observed from his statements. Once while replying to a question from one of his companions, Abu Talib-e-Qummi, Imam (a.s.) wrote, "Write an elegy for my father as well as for me." This reveals that behind the veil of an apparently independent life, Imam (a.s.) was living under strict observation and afflictions and desired that his companions should write elegies to spread the news of his captivity in the society.

In the 17 years of Imamate, Imam (a.s.) saw the reigns of two rulers of Bani Abbas – Mamoon and Mo'tasim. During the reign of Mo'tasim, Imam (a.s.) was forcibly brought from Madinah to Baghdad in Moharram 220 A.H. Despite all the restrictions, Imam (a.s.) fulfilled all his responsibilities in the best possible way. While advising the powerful governor of Seestan, Husain Ibn Abdullah Nishapoori, about his duties and responsibilities, he wrote,

فَاحْسِنْ إِلَى إِخْوَانِكَ وَاعْلَمْ أَنَّ اللَّهَ عَزَّوَجَلَّ سَائِلُكَ عَنْ مَشَاقِيلِ
الدُّرِّ وَالْخَرَدَلِ.

"Behave well with your brothers (the people under your

¹ Wasaael al-Shiah, vol. 13, p. 14, Ch. 3, H. 17117

rule and your religious brothers) and know that Allah the Almighty would question you about each and every small deed.”

And when he intended to advise those who were always justifying their wrong doings, i.e., those who were believers outwardly, but were actually assisting the rulers, he would say,

كُفِيَ لِلْمُؤْمِنِ خِيَانَةً أَنْ يَكُونَ أَمِينًا لِلدَّخُولَةِ.

“Suffice it is for a believer to have committed treason by being a trustworthy for those who are treacherous.”

While inviting his friends towards self control, character building and self purification, he advised,

مِنْ سَلَامَةِ الْإِنْسَانِ قِلَّةُ حِفْظِهِ لِعُيُوبٍ غَيْرِهِ وَعِنَايَتِهِ بِإِصْلَاحِ عُيُوبِ نَفْسِهِ.

“Forgetting others shortcomings and paying attention towards reforming one’s own defects are the signs of a sound human being.”

With regard to the above mentioned ethic, when he wanted to train the Muslims in accepting the useful advices of others, he used to say,

الْمُؤْمِنُ تَحْتَاجُ إِلَى ثَلَاثِ خِصَالٍ: تَوْفِيقٍ مِنَ اللَّهِ وَوَاعِظٍ مِنْ نَفْسِهِ وَقَبُولٍ مِمَّنْ يَنْصَحُهُ.

“A believer requires three characteristics – a divine grace, an advisor from within his own self and the acceptance of the one who advises him.”

Undoubtedly if such incidents are dealt in detail then we will require several more pages to narrate all such episodes. It is sufficient to know that during the 17 years of his Imamate, Imam Taqi (a.s.) protected the luminous light of Imamate while during this period, Bani Abbas tried their best to create a hostile environment and spread false propaganda that at the time of the death of Imam Reza (a.s.), there was no mature son and that a minor cannot fulfill the responsibilities that come with the position of Imamate. During these times, Imam (a.s.) trained self sacrificing friends such as Ibn Abi Umayr Baghdadi, Abu Jafar Mohammad Ibn Sanaan Zaheri, Ahmad Ibn Abi Nasr, Bazant-e-Kufi, Abu Tamaam Habeeb Ibn Aws Taell, Abul Hasan Ali Ibn Mahziyar-e-Ahwaazi, Fazl Ibn Shazaan Nishapoori etc. Thus, he created the ground for further propagation of Shiite teachings despite stiff opposition of the Abbasside government. Although Imam (a.s.) did not adopt a policy of openly opposing the government Bani Abbas, he maintained this advice to his friends –

الْقَصْدُ إِلَى اللَّهِ بِالْقُلُوبِ أَبْدَعُ مِنْ إِثْبَاتِ (اتِّعَابِ) الْجَوَارِحِ بِالْأَعْمَالِ.

“The inclination with heart towards Allah (life and a moment based upon deep rooted and basic aim) is much more expressive than employing (putting into hardship) the body.” (implying an action which is not based on

thinking).¹

Ultimately on Saturday, the last day of the month of Zilqad, 220 A.H. on the command of Mo'tasim, Imam (a.s.) was poisoned by his wife Ummul Fazl (daughter of Mamoon – perhaps, it was for this reason that Mamoon had married his daughter to Imam (a.s.)) which led to his martyrdom at the age of 25 years. He was buried next to the grave of his grand father Imam Musa Kazim (a.s.). This area was later known as Kazmain and even today it remains the centre of attraction for thousands of followers of Imams (a.s.).

To end the chapter, we reproduce below two wise and thoughtful saying of Imam Taqi (a.s.):

1. If we observe that society is plagued by controversies and differences of opinion, we should realise that it is because of the interference of ignorant.

لَوْ سَكَتَ الْجَاهِلُ مَا اخْتَلَفَ النَّاسُ

“If the ignorant remain silent, people will not differ.”²

The above tradition widens the path in our lives and advises us to avoid useless discussions.

2. Man in his social life should try not to be attached to those who are wicked in character and whose thoughts are not correct.

Imam (a.s.) says,

إِيَّاكَ وَ مُصَاحِبَةَ الشَّرِيرِ فَإِنَّهُ كَالسَّيْفِ الْمَسْلُوقِ يَحْسُنُ مَنَظَرُهُ وَ يَقْبَحُ أَثَرُهُ.

“Do not associate yourselves with a wicked person. Surely he is like a naked sword which looks good but has evil effects.”¹

We hope these sayings of Imam Mohammad Taqi (a.s.) will change our mind, heart, spirit and conscience for good and help us develop as better human beings. Inshallah.

¹ Al-Kaafi, vol. 5, p. 111, H. 6

² Kashf al-Ghummah, vol. 2, p. 349

¹ Mustadrak al-Wasaael, vol. 8, p. 351, H. 9634

In 220 AH, after the martyrdom of Imam Mohammad Taqi (a.s.), the responsibility of Imamate came upon the young Imam who was, at that time, only eight years old. Of his several titles, ‘Hadi’ and ‘Naqi’ are the most popular. Generally, he is remembered more as ‘Imam Ali Naqi’ and ‘Imam Hadi.’ His Kuniyyat is ‘Abul Hasan.’

Caliphs during his Era

During the 34 years of his life, Imam Ali Naqi (a.s.) passed through six caliphs of Bani Abbas, namely Mo’tasim, Waathiq, Mutawakkil, Muntasir, Mustaeen and Mo’taz. All six of them followed the footsteps of their fathers and tried to create as much difficulties for Imam (a.s.) as possible.

His stay in Saamarra

Amongst the calamities that Imam (a.s.) faced, was the deportation of the Prophet’s (s.a.w.a.) progeny from Madinah to Saamarra (which was the capital of Muslim rule). This deportation took place during Mutawakkil’s reign. After this deportation, there was a significant increase in the injustice and tortures afflicted on the Imams (a.s.) by the Umayyad and Abbasside caliphs and their agents. These injustices were done under the direct supervision of the Caliph. Mutawakkil’s agents had reported from Makkah and Madinah that if you want these two cities, then deport Imam (a.s.) from here.

On account of this and due to other factors, Mutawakkil took this step. Mutawakkil’s desperation becomes more evident when we

Lesson No. 17

Imam Ali Naqi (a.s.)

وَأَخْتِمُ بِالسَّعَادَةِ لِابْنِهِ عَلِيٍّ وَلِيِّ وَ نَاصِرِي وَالشَّاهِدِ فِي خَلْقِي
وَأَمِينِي عَلَى وَحْيِي.

“And I concluded with bliss for his son Ali, My friend and My helper and a witness upon My creation and My trustworthy upon My revelation.”¹

Name	: Hazrat Ali Ibn Mohammad (a.s.)
Father’s name	: Hazrat Imam Mohammad Taqi (a.s.)
Mother’s name	: Samaana
Date of Birth	: 15 th Zil hijjah 212 A.H.
Place of Birth	: Madinah Munawwarah (at Surya)
Kuniyyat	: Abul Hasan
Titles	: Naseh, Murtaza, Ameen, Naqi
Age	: 42 years
Martyrdom	: 3 rd Rajab 254 AH
Buried	: Saamarra

He was born in the second half of Zilhajj 212 A.H. in a suburb of Madinah called ‘Surya’, in the house of Imam Mohammad Taqi (a.s.) and ‘Samaana’. He was named ‘Ali’ like three of his

¹ Hadees-e-Lauh

see how he placed Imam (a.s.) in a military cantonment ('Askar'). Imam (a.s.) passed more than 20 years of his life in this 'prison'. Thus, the government kept an eye on each and every contact and meeting of Imam (a.s.). Not satisfied with this, based on the reports of his spies and sycophants, the government often raided the house of the Imam (a.s.) unannounced, alleging that he was gathering arms and mobilising his friends for attempting a rebellion against the government. Under this excuse, every nook and corner of the Imam's (a.s.) house was searched.

This aspect of Imam's (a.s.) life highlights that the tyrannical Abbasside government was under tremendous stress and also brings forth the extent of the fear of the Ahle Bait (a.s.) in the hearts of the rulers.

The ability to lead society, profound knowledge, piety, righteousness and awareness was abundant in our Imams (a.s.). The society and members of the ruling government were well aware of this fact.

Hazrat Imam Ali Naqi (a.s.) was raised to the status of Imamate at the age of eight.

In the writings of Shias, all the words and wills of Imam Jawad (a.s.) are present, which during his 17 years of Imamate emphasized again and again about the Imamate of Imam Ali Naqi (a.s.). This was done in order to repel the evil designs of Bani Abbas that they do not use the young age of Imam Ali Naqi (a.s.) as a pretext against his Imamate. In this period, the Abbasside government decided against its policy of conducting open discussions and debates with the Imam (a.s.). This was because in every such debate the holy personality of the Imam (a.s.) was

manifested even more splendidly before the people.

One day, Yahya Ibn Aktham (who was disgraced by Imam Mohammad Taqi (a.s.) innumerable times) approached in a gathering the brother of Imam (a.s.), Musa Ibn Mohammad ar-Reza, and asked him a few questions about the Holy Quran, history of the dawn of Islam and a few judgments of Imam Ali (a.s.) and demanded his answers. He (Musa) was not well versed with such topics. Hence the questions were directed to Imam Naqi (a.s.) who smiled and asked Yahya Ibn Aktham to repeat the questions. He repeated the questions and their complications (there were about 14 different ones) in front of Imam (a.s.). He gave all the replies immediately and instructed his brother to send the same to Yahya Ibn Aktham in writing who in turn carried out the instructions.

During his 34 years tenure of Imamate, Imam Ali Naqi (a.s.) bore a lot of difficulties and problems inflicted on him by the six Abbasside caliphs and their agents, but spared no effort when it came to the true guidance of the Islamic society.

The Worship of Imam (a.s.)

His worship and obedience of Allah was famous and he possessed tremendous spiritual power. The following incident is the best example of these two characteristics. During the reign of Mutawakkil, government servants raided the house of Imam (a.s.) with the objective of finding arms and letters of Shias (by which it could be established that they were plotting against the government). When they entered they saw Imam (a.s.) in the corner of the house where even the necessities of life were not provided in a condition that he was sitting on stones with a woolen

cover on his head. Imam (a.s.) was engrossed in the worship of Allah and reciting verses of Qur'an which speak about hope and fear. The mercenaries of the government took the Imam (a.s.) along with the same stones and woolen blanket to Mutawakkil who was busy drinking. On seeing the Imam (a.s.) he was so overawed that he regained his consciousness. Respecting the Imam (a.s.), he made him sit next to the throne and after some conversation he requested the Imam (a.s.) to recite some couplets.

Initially the Imam (a.s.) refused, but Mutawakkil did not relent. Finally he (a.s.) recited such verses in front of Mutawakkil, his courtiers and dignitaries, the topics and contents which forced a man as hard hearted as Mutawakkil to break down. Even those who were around Mutawakkil started weeping. Mutawakkil ordered his men to take Imam (a.s.) home with utmost respect.

Take Advantage of Opportunities

From this incident one comes to know that Imam (a.s.) was a perfect symbol of all Islamic teachings because Islam has taught not to go only after the world. In contrast, it ordered man to pay more attention to worship and moral aspects of his life. Imam's (a.s.) life was a symbol of such teachings. Islam neither encourages kingly lavishness nor does it advocate the manner of the ascetics. Imam (a.s.) also adopted the same method. On spotting the opportunity he did not fail to admonish a blood sucker like Mutawakkil. We also gain another lesson from this incident that according to the saying,

الْفُرْصَةُ تَنْتَرُّ مَرَّ السَّحَابِ فَاعْتَبِرُوا فُرْصَ الْخَيْرِ

“Opportunity passes away like a cloud. Therefore make use of good opportunities.”

In the field of benevolence and nobility, Imam (a.s.) was a model. When one reads the incident of Imam (a.s.) which the historians have noted down in their books, one may even think of his generosity as miraculous.

Appointment of Deputies

Due to circumstances, Imam (a.s.) appointed reliable deputies so that the restrictions imposed by the government should not become the cause for people to remain far from religious judgments of daily necessities and from turning towards the Imam (a.s.). Amongst these deputies was Abu Amr Usman Ibn Saeed Amri, who later became the deputy of Imam Hasan Askari (a.s.) and Imam Mahdi (a.s.). Thus it was like preparing the field for Imam-e-Zaman (a.s.) to appoint deputies and the aim was to teach the people that in case they cannot approach the Imam of the time for religious verdicts, they must know how to obtain them.

Nevertheless, Imam after facing all such troubles never stopped teaching and training the people. There are several traditions from the Imam (a.s.) found in Islamic writings which display clearly how much the Imam (a.s.) was sensitive to this matter.

Self Admiration

For removing the defects in character of his followers, he (a.s.) said,

مَنْ رَضِيَ عَنْ نَفْسِهِ كَثُرَ السَّخِطُونَ عَلَيْهِ

“The one who is satisfied with himself indulges in self admiration. (The result will be that) an increasing number of people will be against him.”¹

Thus he would teach his followers how to attract people towards them and how to reduce the number of their antagonists.

Patience

Whenever he admonished his followers to be steadfast and keep patience, he (a.s.) advised,

الْصَّيْبَةُ لِلصَّابِرِ وَاحِدَةٌ وَلِلْجَارِعِ اثْنَانِ

“Sorrow is single for the patient and double for the despicable.”²

(One who is patient bears only sorrow and calamities, while the one who is impatient, along with sorrow and calamities, he also has to bear his disability).

World is Preparation for the Hereafter

Whenever he wanted to remind the people of their transient lives, he said,

الدُّنْيَا سُوقٌ رُبِحَ فِيهَا قَوْمٌ وَخَسِرَ آخَرُونَ.

“The world is a market in which one group benefits (because they are well aware and work in it) while the

other loses. (because they are unmindful and deep in slumber)”¹

Supplications

Invocations have also been noted from Imam Ali Naqi (a.s.) in which every prayer has a world of understanding in its lap.

Imam Ali Naqi (a.s.) enjoys such a status in the history of Islam that the greatest scholars of Ahle Sunnat have mentioned him in their writings. Ibn Khallekaan in Wafayaatul A'yaan, volume 2, page 435; Mohammad Ibn Talha Shafaei in Mataalebus So'l, page 188; Ibn Hajar Haithami in al-Sawaaeq al-Mohreqah, page 205. Each one of them has remembered Imam (a.s.) in their books and in various ways mentioned his greatness.

Martyrdom

Finally, on the command of Moa'taz Abbasi, Imam (a.s.) was poisoned and martyred on Monday, 3rd Rajab 254 A.H. at the age of 42 years. His martyrdom worsened the image of the Abbasids.

His holy body was buried in his house in Saamarra. Today visitors from every nook and corner come to his grave and through his holy self try to gain proximity with Allah the Almighty. To end this lesson, we quote an extract from the invocation of Imam (a.s.) which he used to recite in Qunoot. This invocation to some extent conveys those heart rending problems which Imam (a.s.) had faced in his 34 years of Imamate.

¹ Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 72, p. 316, Ch. 117, H. 24, narrating from al-Durrah al-Baaherah

² Mustadrak al-Wasaael, vol. 2, p. 445, Ch. 68, H. 2420

¹ Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 78, p. 366, Ch. 28, narrating from Tohaf al-Oqool

اللَّهُمَّ اكْشِفِ الْعَذَابَ عَنِ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ وَابْعَثْ جَهْرَةً عَلَى
الظَّالِمِينَ. اللَّهُمَّ بَادِرْ عَصَبَةَ الْحَقِّ بِالْعَوْنِ وَبَادِرْ أَعْوَانَ الظُّلْمِ
بِالنَّقْصِ.

“O Allah! Save the believers from your wrath and incur that wrath on the unjust. O Allah! Hasten to help the people of truth and hasten to destroy the helpers of injustice.”¹

Lesson No. 18

Imam Hasan Askari (a.s.)

أُخْرِجْ مِنْهُ الدَّاعِيَ إِلَى سَبِيلِي ﷺ وَالْخَازِنَ لِعِلْمِي الْحَسَنَ.

“I will bring from him (Imam Hadi (a.s.)) a caller towards My path and a treasurer of My knowledge, Hasan.”¹

Name	: Hazrat Hasan Ibn Ali (a.s.)
Father's name	: Hazrat Imam Ali Naqi (a.s.)
Mother's name	: Saleel, Sousan
Date of Birth	: 8 Rabi us Thaani 232 AH
Place of Birth	: Madinah Munawwarah
Kuniyyat	: Abu Mohammad
Titles	: Askari, Khalis, Zaki, Hadi etc
Age	: 28 years
Martyrdom	: 8th Rabiul Awwal, 260 AH
Buried	: Saamarra

Imam Hasan Askari (a.s.) was born on the 8th of Rabi us Thaani, 232 AH in Madinah. His mother's name was 'Saleel'. His Kuniyyat was Abu Mohammad. His moral, spiritual and physical characteristics are mentioned in historical books, greatly

¹ Mohaj al-Da'waat, p. 60; Qunoot of our Master, Imam Ali Ibn Muhammad al-Zaki (a.s.)

¹ Hadees-e-Lauh

emphasizing on his majesty and grandeur. After the martyrdom of his father in 254 A.H., he took the reins of the nation's affairs in his hand at the age of 22. He spent the six years of his Imamate with three Abbasside caliphs, Mo'taz, Mohtadi and Motamid. He spent his entire life under severe pressure of the government. To know the reason behind his title 'Askari', it should be remembered as mentioned in the lesson of Imam Ali Naqi (a.s.) that they were forcibly kept in a military cantonment (Askar) in Saamarra. The Imam spent most of the time of his Imamate in this area under strict government vigilance and hence the title of Askari was given to him. (Bahlul Behjat Affandi mentions this point emphatically in his book 'Tashrih wa Muhakamah Dar Tarikh-e-Ale Mohammad, page 245.' (He is a Shafaei Sunni writer). It will suffice to know that the main reason for the unlimited harassment of the government towards the Imam (a.s.) was to a great extent directly related to the matter of belief of the people that the real avenger and the one who will return the right of the innocent and oppressed from the oppressors – Imam Mahdi Hujjat Ibnil Hasan (a.s.) will be from his progeny. The Abbasids were certain of this prophecy because of their true reporters and informers. Therefore they made every attempt that the child should not come into this world at all.

Due to these restrictions, Imam (a.s.) had appointed his representatives for the ease of his followers so that through them, people could solve their problems and connect with Imam (a.s.). These representatives were bearers of great personalities and were highly respected amongst the Shias. Amongst these representatives were Uthman Ibn Saeed Amri and his son Mohammad Ibn Uthman.

The life history of Imam (a.s.) notes that he was always kept under the surveillance of hard hearted and tyrannical jailors. Amongst this evil group we also find the name of Saleh Ibn Waseef. In the past, the Abbasids made every attempt in destroying the manifested unity of the Shiahs. Often the tomb of Imam Husain (a.s.) which was a centre to keep alive the spirit of Imam Husain's (a.s.) revolution and a factor for inspiring the Shiahs towards a struggle and striving was flooded with water (as was done at the time of Mutawakkil). At other times, they used to block the path of eager visitors to Imam (a.s.) and also give orders for destroying the shrine of Imam (a.s.). Many a times they also used to manifest their military strength and superficial power in order to create a threat in the hearts of Shiahs (like the march of 90,000 well-equipped soldiers in Saamarra in front of Imam Ali Naqi (a.s.)).

A lot has been said about the spiritual, moral and Islamic characteristics of Imam (a.s.), some of which are recorded in the pages of history. He had no parallel in worship and piety, so much so that when two of the most wicked agents of Saleh Ibn Waseef (the jailor of Imam (a.s.)) were forced by the Abbasids to be more severe with Imam (a.s.), they would describe him in the following words, "What do you say about such a great man who fasts during the day and worships Allah during the night. He does not speak much and does not engage himself except in worship and obedience. When he looks at us, we begin to tremble involuntarily (a trembling due to the magnificence of Imam (a.s.)), and his fear sinks deep down into our heart."¹

In order to circumvent the severe restrictions of the government,

¹ Al-Kaafi, vol. 1, p. 512, H. 23

Imam (a.s.) placed a great emphasis on ‘Taqaiyyah.’ This was done in order to reduce the government pressure as also to ensure that Shias enjoy a better existence and create a centre for Shiah. He used to command his companions like Dawood Ibn Aswad not to be so offensive towards the detractors of Imam (a.s.) and to continue his own work.

This matter advises us that Shias should determine their own course in the society in accordance with the needs prevailing in the society so that maximum results are achieved with minimum resources and that they should not unnecessarily take superficial steps which are in fact hindrances. Perhaps the reason for the scattering of the famous companions of Imam (a.s.) in different corners (like Abu Ali Ahmed Ibn Ishaq Ashari in Qum and Abu Sahl Ismail Naubakhti in Baghdad) and remaining far from him during this period was due to the fact that they were working under the cover of ‘Taqaiyyah’ and at the same time were spreading the Shiah culture.

Amongst the most important works left behind from Imam Hasan Askari (a.s.) is a Tafseer on Holy Qur’an which has been published several times over the years 1268 A.H. to 1315 A.H. and is available at present. His method of explanation of the verses of Qur’an was adopted and followed to a great extent by famous Shiah scholars like Shaikh Saduq (r.a.), Shaikh Tabrisi (r.a.) and Allamah Majlisi (r.a.).

The valuable sayings and advices of Imam (a.s.) which are in our hands are an illuminator of the path to be adopted by the followers. Regarding the general behaviour of Shiah he says,

Be an Ornament for Us

اَتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَكُونُوا زِينًا وَلَا تَكُونُوا شَيْنًا. جُرُّوا إِلَيْنَا كُلَّ مَوَدَّةٍ وَادْفَعُوا عَنَّا قَبِيحًا.

“Be careful (of your duty) towards Allah. Be an ornament for us and do not be a disgrace for us. Attract the love of others towards us and repel the evils (which attack the belief in us) away from us.”¹

When he wanted to brighten the saddened hearts of his followers and give them glad tidings of a bright future despite the prevalent anxiety, he would address his close friends and companions like Ali Ibnil Husain Ibn Musa Ibn Babwayh Qummi to whom he wrote,

Patience and Awaiting

...عَلَيْكَ بِالصَّبْرِ وَاتِّظَارِ الْفَرَجِ فَإِنَّ النَّبِيَّ قَالَ أَفْضَلُ أَعْمَالٍ أُمِّتِي اتِّظَارُ الْفَرَجِ وَلَا تَزَالُ شِيعَتُنَا فِي حُزْنٍ حَتَّى يَظْهَرَ وَلَدِي الَّذِي بَشَّرَ بِهِ النَّبِيُّ..... عَلَى أَمْرِ جَبِيْعٍ شِيعَتِي بِالصَّبْرِ.

“I advise you to be patient and to wait for ‘faraj’ (because) surely the Holy Prophet (s.a.w.a) said; The best act of my people is to wait for the ‘faraj’. Our people will always be engulfed in sorrows and troubles so much so

¹ Mustadrak al-Wasa'el, vol. 8, p. 314, Ch. 1, H. 9531

that my son the one whose glad tidings (of reappearance) was given by the Holy Prophet will emerge. Advise all the Shiahs on my behalf to be steadfast and patient.”¹

On one hand, we see how Imam (a.s.) in the form of advice invites the Shiahs to adopt a high standard of morals so that it is the cause for attracting the love and affection (of the people) towards the Prophet’s household (a.s.) On the other hand, he recommends them to be firm and steadfast because one will have to face many hardships while proceeding on this path.

The Door of Paradise

In a society that was ruled by the Abbasids, the corruption which had originated from the centre of caliphate and spread till the far corners of the society and in its due course had destroyed all sorts of decency and goodness, Imam (a.s.) used to advice his companions towards their awareness. He would say,

إِنَّ فِي الْجَنَّةِ بَابًا يُقَالُ لَهُ بَابُ الْمَعْرُوفِ لَا يَدْخُلُهُ إِلَّا أَهْلُ
الْمَعْرُوفِ.

“There is a door in heaven called ‘Babul Ma’roof’ (the door of goodness) and none will enter it except people with goodness (in their actions).”²

In this way, Imam (a.s.) enlivened the quality of goodness in the

minds of the people. Imam (a.s.) in a short sentence warns those who adopt falsehood that they would finally regret it. Thus he said,

مَنْ رَكِبَ ظَهْرَ الْبَاطِلِ نَزَلَ بِهِ دَارَ النَّدَامَةِ.

“One who rides on the back of falsehood will be made to descent the abode of regret.”¹

During the brief period of Imamate, Imam (a.s.) (despite the pressures due to the restrictions of the government upon him) not only attracted the attention of the Shiahs and the scholars but also of the Sunnis and a group of their scholars (who were not apparently believing in Imam’s (a.s.) Imamate). It was to the extent that books like Matalebus So’l, page 88 by Mohammad Ibn Talha Shafaei, Tazkeratul Khawaas, page 203 by Sibte Ibn Jauzi, Fusoolul Mohimmah, page 272 by Ibn Sabbagh-e-Maaleki, Al Athaaf Be Hubbil Ashraaf, page 68 by Muhammad Shabraavi Shafaei, reflect a great portion of the details of Imam’s (a.s.) style, attributes characteristics, miracles which cannot be accommodated in this small treatise.

The period of six years of Hazrat’s Imamate ended and the people inspite of all the difficulties benefitted as much as they could from him. Ultimately on the command of Mo’tamid Abbasi, Imam (a.s.) was poisoned at the age of 28 years. The poison delayed its effect and gradually Imam’s (a.s.) health began to decline and he fell seriously ill.

When Mo’tamid heard of this, he sent his special servant Nehree-e-Khadim along with his other agents to serve him and appointed a

¹ Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 50, p. 317, Ch. 4, narrating from Manaageb of Ibn Shahr

² Mustadrak al-Wasaael, vol. 12, p. 343, H. 14243

¹ Behaar al-Anwaar, vol. 78, p. 379, Ch. 29, narrating from Kanz al-Fawaaed

doctor to look after him. When his fast declining health led Imam (a.s.) towards death, Mo'tamid ordered the Qazaelul Qozaat (Chief Justice) to go to Imam's (a.s.) bedside with famous and known scholars and ordered them to prepare and sign false testimonies stating that Imam (a.s.) had died a natural death. This act itself proves how much the powerful Abbasids were fearful of the hidden Shiah strength that they had to play such a fraud on the people.

Thus, on 8th Rabiul Awwal, 260 A.H., Imam (a.s.) was martyred. On the caliph's order, the house of Imam (a.s.) was searched by his agents in order to verify that he had not left behind a son. Allah put a veil on their eyes and they could see nothing. Therefore, they pushed Ja'far, the brother of Imam Hasan Askari (a.s.) and accorded him apparent respect to show that the chain of Imamate was over and that expectations of the society (that Imam (a.s.) Mahdi would destroy all the oppressive governments) will not become a reality. In 260 A.H., with the martyrdom of Imam Askari (a.s.), the Imamate or leadership of the community took a new turn which will be represented in detail in the forthcoming chapters.

The holy body of Imam Hasan Askari (a.s.) was buried in his ancestral home near the grave of his father. (Peace be on them all)